

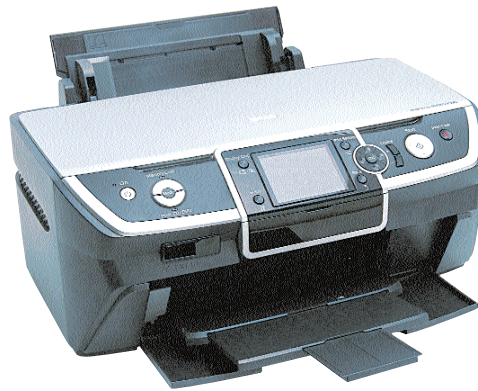
Epson Stylus PHOTO R390

A photoholic's companion

No, we didn't emphasise that, Epson did. As the capital letters suggest, the Epson R390 is indeed a ~Photo printer. Epson has packaged a lot of functionality into the massive-looking R390, which is nearly as big as some MFDs we've come across. Build quality is very good, right down to the movable parts, which look like they can stand the rigours of daily use. With an aggressive, forward-sloping design, the R390 looks good, and the grey and silver colour tone goes well with the sculpt.

The front of the printer is adorned with more buttons than ever. The 3.5-inch LCD screen gives you previews of what you're printing. While not necessary when printing from a PC, it's most welcome while using the PictBridge slot, or any of the memory slots (MS Pro, CF, xD, SD) as the image source.

The software suite is suitably rich and deviates from Epson's



regular bundle by including an Image Editing Studio (Epson's own). An ultra-convenient RAW plugin is also provided for working with professional-grade RAW image files. Then there's the CD/DVD printing utility sporting a user-friendly yet powerful interface.

Once we got to using the R390, we were pretty amazed at how far photo printers have really come. But it's a pity that specialisation means losing out on

general capabilities. The R390 produced abysmal results printing text at draft settings. In fact, the text looked more brown than black!

We expected a turnaround of sorts at the higher settings, but that just didn't happen, not to the expected levels anyway. The R390 refused to get text printing right.

Our combination document fared much better, particularly the embedded photograph—this printer aced *that* test. However, performance on the whole was a mixed bundle: the highlights on the fruit were missing—in fact, the berries in our combination document looked like spherical lumps of clay. The R390 performed well on the reverse text front, much better than the HP printers, but that's an unfair comparison when you look at the prices.

Our photo printout took just 66.2 seconds to complete—excellent for an A4 size sheet! Considering the quality of the printout, we can easily recommend the Epson R390 as a photo printer.

With great colour reproduction and proper rendition of finer details (the dimples on the golf balls aside, that is, which looked better on the D4168), the R390 also produced great-looking skin tones with accurate highlighting. This makes it really suitable for portrait photos.

It's got features galore, it's got a host of connectivity options, and it showed some great printing results in the domain of its expertise—so we'd recommend Epson's R390 for photo printing professionals. You'll have to cough up Rs 15,000 for it, though.

Media Issues!

Take the best printer in the world, give it some very ordinary consumables, and the results would be substandard. Sure we all know our printers. But how well do we know our media? Manufacturers take pains to assure consumers of the fact that the choice of media greatly affects quality of output. The problem in India is the low availability of both knowledge about and availability of printer media (both inkjet and laser).

Most users will typically use either photocopy paper or executive bond paper in their inkjet printers. While the results may be acceptable for regular document printing, must better results can be had if you make an informed buying decision when choosing media.

Firstly paper is classified on the basis of its weight, which determines its quality. The unit of measurement is GSM or Grams per Square Meter. In general the higher the GSM value (i.e. heavier paper) the better its quality. The difference in weight is mainly due to the thickness of the sheet. This thickness isn't due to the paper being thick though. Most print media undergoes heavy processing especially photo papers which have to be imbued with certain desirous qualities like fade resistance, water resistance, blot-free, smudge resistance and even resistance to wear and tear. The processing involves either coatings applied to the surface of the paper, or molecular level treatment, whereby substances are embedded into the sheet of paper. These substances could be micro-ceramic coatings - to enable quick drying for heavy ink jobs, or wax treatment to help resist moisture.

For example 80 GSM paper is considered the norm for regular office use. 100 GSM paper is basically Executive Bond, used for letterheads and such. Anything over 130 GSM is considered as Card Paper for printing colour brochures, pamphlets etc. Photograph printing can be done on anything around 130 GSM or above. Anything thinner should not be considered for photo printouts simply because the chances of blotting are very high. Professional photo printers will use glossy or matte finish papers (depending on their requirements) to the tune of up to 245 GSM. For regular photo printouts matte or glossy photo papers with a GSM rating of 160 will suffice.

The Big Guns—How They Fared

